SkillBridge — Pitch, Interview Scripts & Validation (Final)

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The student problem is supported by survey, pilot and interview evidence. Students' willingness to pay and recruiters' trust in the certificate are conditional, and a two-arm pilot on 16–30 Oct decides the model.

1. Problem and target user

Tech students applying for internships are asked to show work beyond coursework and explain what they personally did, and most can't.

Student (user)	A 2nd–4th-year software, web or data student whose experience is mainly coursework
Job to be done	When applying for internships and asked for project examples, have practical work they can show and explain to an employer
Pain	They need experience to get an internship, and an internship to get experience. Group projects hide who did what, and personal projects go unreviewed
Current alternatives	Coursework, unfinished side projects, Forage simulations, HackerRank, Devpost and Kaggle. None gives company-calibrated feedback plus a record of individual contribution
Company (customer)	A SaaS, engineering or data company that hires interns or juniors and wants a better screen than a CV
Recruiter (decides credential value)	Screens hundreds of CVs in seconds each and can't tell who did what in a group repo

2. Solution and value proposition

One line: SkillBridge lets tech students solve short, real challenges set by SaaS, engineering and data companies, and turns each result into a company-calibrated score with a verified record of what each student contributed.

20-second version:

> Companies keep shortlisting on university names because a CV can't prove skill. Students with real ability get overlooked: they need experience to get an internship, and an internship to get experience. SkillBridge breaks that loop. Students spend two to seven hours on a short, real brief from a tech company, alone or in a small team. Automated tests and an AI rubric score every submission, the company's engineer signs off the rubric and writes the feedback, and each student's own contribution is on the record. Recruiters get proof of the work, not adjectives on a CV.

How it works:

1. A company gives one small, self-contained brief (no production access, no customer data) and its own criteria for "good".
2. Students submit solo or in teams of up to three; teams log who did what in their commits or task list.
3. Automated tests and an AI rubric score every submission; the engineer spot-checks the ranking, including one low-ranked submission.
4. The student sees their score free. The certified result is an evidence bundle: the work, rubric breakdown with the company's name, contribution record and engineer-written feedback.
5. Results are private by default. The student chooses what to share, the true score always shows, and it is possible to fail.
6. Students keep their code; companies use the task for assessment only.

3. Assumptions to validate

The model rests on three actors behaving as assumed. The riskiest is that students will pay for a certified score because employers treat it as credible evidence of job-ready skill (A1.3 + A3.1).

ID	Actor	Assumption	Importance	Status after this round
A1.1	Student	Students struggle to prove skill and personal contribution	High	Supported
A1.2	Student	Students will finish a 2–7 hour challenge with no prize	High	Stated only; timing is a risk
A1.3	Student	Students will pay €15 to certify a result	High	Conditional on engineer feedback and recognition
A2.1	Company	A company will give a real brief and sign off a rubric	High	Promising; brief not yet signed
A2.2	Company	Engineer review takes about an hour per challenge	Medium	Estimated, not measured
A2.3	Company	AI rubric scores agree with the engineer closely enough	Medium	Untested
A3.1	Recruiter	Recruiters trust the certified result enough to shortlist on it	High	Conditional: they trust the evidence bundle, not a bare score
A3.3	Recruiter	The certificate can replace a company's take-home test	Medium	Conditional: their own brief plus a short live check

4. Method

Four rounds of evidence, kept separate because their participants may overlap. All are stated behaviour or intentions; none observes a payment, submission or hire.

Source	Date	Who	n	Strength
Student survey	Sep 2026	Students (university and year not recorded)	17	Medium: stated, unscreened

Source	Date	Who	n	Strength
Pilot findings	1 Oct 2026	3rd-year software students in Madrid	11	Medium: reported, aggregate only
V2 interviews	5, 6 and 10 Oct 2026	1 IE CSAI student, 1 recruiter, 1 company engineer	3	Medium: real interviews, one per role
One-on-one interviews	Date to be added	1 graduate, 1 current IE student, 1 recruiter	3	Low–medium: no dates or context recorded; direct questions about price

Interviews asked about recent behaviour before describing SkillBridge, then tested reactions to the idea and the €15 price. The scripts are in Appendices A and B.

5. Results: expected vs. heard

The student pain is supported; payment and recruiter trust are conditional and still untested by real behaviour.

The pain, in numbers (student survey, n = 17; pilot n = 11 reported separately because the samples may overlap):

- 14/17 find it hard to explain their personal contribution (pilot: 9/11)
- 12/17 struggle to show experience beyond coursework (pilot: 9/11)
- 9/17 say their latest project was seen only by class or staff
- 12/17 can give four hours a week or less; 0/17 can give eight or more

Expected vs heard:

Assumption	Expected	Heard	Verdict
Students are stuck in the experience loop	Can't prove skill beyond coursework	V2 student froze when asked "which parts did you write?", never heard back, then started a solo project (60% done, never reviewed)	Supported

Assumption	Expected	Heard	Verdict
Team contribution is invisible	Recruiters can't tell who did what	V2 recruiter: 400 applications for 6 places, 90 seconds or less each; can't tell who did what in group repos. One-on-one recruiter: verified contribution makes an interview more likely	Supported
Students pay €15 to certify	Yes, if credible	Three students say yes, all conditional on engineer-written feedback or recruiter recognition. Graduate: €5–10 while the platform is new. Current student: tops out at €20–25	Conditional
Recruiters trust the score	The number is the hero	V2 recruiter would skip a bare 82/100. Both recruiters want the rubric, company review and the actual work sample; one adds anti-cheating checks and a benchmark of how others scored	Revised: evidence bundle
Students fit a short challenge	2–7 hours fits	One-on-one students: 3–5 and 4–6 hours a week. V2 student: four hours clashes with deadlines	Supported, timing matters
Solo or team	Unclear	Both one-on-one students want a mix: teams feel like real work, solo shows personal contribution	Offer both, track contribution

Assumption	Expected	Heard	Verdict
Companies supply challenges	Yes, if low effort	V2 engineer offered a real CSV-validation task and 5 criteria: “Send me three zips and a deadline”; about 1 hour to review three	Promising, brief not signed

6. Revenue: who pays

The team ranks students paying first, but every new interviewee says companies should carry most of the cost. None of the three hypotheses is validated; the pilot decides.

Rank	Hypothesis	Evidence for	Evidence against
1	Students pay €15 to certify a result	V2 student: “Fifteen euros is two coffees,” if a real engineer writes the feedback. Both one-on-one students would pay €15 if recruiters recognise it	Every alternative (Forage, HackerRank, Kaggle) is free. The graduate would pay only €5–10 while the platform is new. Both students say companies should pay. Student fees alone in Madrid stay under €9,000 a year at the 30% threshold
2	Companies pay to use challenges as a hiring screen	V2 recruiter: take-home review is “the expensive part”; could argue to pay if it replaces it. One-on-one recruiter: companies should pay for a pre-screened pool	No price, budget or agreement yet. Payment is not the engineer's decision

Rank	Hypothesis	Evidence for	Evidence against
3	Companies pay a sponsorship for employer branding	V2 recruiter's team sponsored a hackathon (about 8k, currency not stated) from a talent-brand budget; the engineer's company also sponsors	Branding value of a 2–7 h challenge is untested

Market anchors from desk research, not SkillBridge prices: HackerRank from $79 a month, Riipen $11.67 per student-hour, hackathon sponsorship $500 to $50k+. Company prices stay blank until Arm A's company contact and Arm B's recruiters name a figure.

7. Decisions from the evidence

The team changed four parts of the offer on 12 Oct in response to the interviews. Price, thresholds and the pilot window stay unchanged.

Decision	Driven by
Every paying student gets feedback written by the company's engineer, not only the top three	The student would pay only for human, specific feedback
The certified result is an evidence bundle (work, rubric breakdown, contribution record, engineer's note), never a bare score	Both recruiters discount an unexplained number and want the rubric and work sample
Results are private by default; the student chooses what to share; the true score always shows and it is possible to fail	Students fear a bad public score and a certificate that money can buy
The CSV task becomes a written, signed brief by 20 Oct, or the recruiter arm runs alone	The engineer's proposal is verbal; nothing is signed
Prepare a company-pays offer alongside the €15 student fee	All three one-on-one interviewees say companies should pay

The last row is a recommendation from this round, not yet a team decision.

8. Next test: 16–30 Oct

Riskiest assumption: students will pay for a certified challenge score because employers treat that score as credible evidence of job-ready skill.

A two-arm concierge pilot tests both halves at once. Thresholds are fixed before the test and not adjusted after.

Arm	Who	What happens	Passes if
A	Students	One 4-hour challenge from a real company brief (or an illustrative one if none is signed by 16 Oct). Free to enter; certified result for €15, refundable within 14 days	At least 30% of submitters pay, with at least 10 submissions
B	Recruiters	5+ recruiters see the same CV with and without the full certified bundle	At least 3 of 5 say it would change or support a shortlist

Decision rule:

	Arm B passes	Arm B fails
Arm A passes	Continue: build the working version, sign a second company	Narrow: sell practice and feedback, drop the hiring-credential claim
Arm A fails	Change revenue: students free, companies pay for the screen	Stop the credential model

Given the one-on-one answers, “Arm A fails, Arm B passes” is a live outcome; prepare the company-pays offer now.

Deadlines: written CSV brief and engineer sign-off by 20 Oct (owner: Lucas Avila), or Arm B runs alone. Also add a dated Markdown record of `one_on_one.docx` to the repo’s evidence log.

9. Limitations

The evidence shows the problem is real; it does not yet show anyone will pay or hire on the result.

- **Stated, not observed.** No payment, challenge submission, signed rubric or hiring decision has been recorded.
- **Small samples.** One interview per role in the V2 round and three one-on-ones; survey and pilot respondents may overlap, so their counts are never added.
- **Unscreened survey.** University, programme and year were not collected.
- **One-on-one gaps.** No dates, participant context or consent record; price questions were asked directly, which invites yes answers.
- **Mock profiles not kept.** The exact profiles shown to the V2 recruiter are not attached.
- **No company price.** No company has named a figure; the market anchors in section 6 are other platforms' prices.

Appendix A: Student interview script

Interview a 2nd–4th-year software, web or data student whose experience is mainly coursework. Ask about what they actually did, then describe the idea with its price, then test payment.

#	Ask	Listen for
1	Walk me through the last internship you applied to. What did it ask for?	A request for projects and their personal role
2	What did you show, and did anyone ask what you personally did?	Freezing or sounding vague: the contribution problem
3	What did you build in the last six months to have something to show? How did it end?	Unfinished, unreviewed side projects
4	Have you used Forage, HackerRank, Devpost or Kaggle? What happened?	"Nobody checked"; certificates no one asked about
5	Have you ever paid to improve your hiring chances? What, how much, and why then?	Paying when a specific deadline is close (e.g. LeetCode before an interview)
6	(Describe the idea and the €15 price.) What would make you not bother?	Timing, company recognition, fear of a bad public score
7	How many hours a week could you realistically give? Solo or team?	2–7 hours; a mix of solo and team

#	Ask	Listen for
8	Would you pay €15 to certify the result? If not, how much?	A conditional yes; the condition is your requirement (engineer feedback, recognition)
9	Who should pay: students or companies? Why?	Both one-on-one students said companies, with at most a small student fee
10	What would make this look worthless on a classmate's profile?	Everyone has one; money buys the pass; you can't fail it

Close by asking for permission to send the pilot link (16 Oct) and for one classmate to talk to.

Appendix B: Company interview script

Ask about the problem before describing SkillBridge. Interview a recruiter or hiring manager at a SaaS, engineering or data company who screened interns or juniors in the last 12 months.

#	Ask	Listen for
1	How do you find and shortlist junior or intern talent today?	LinkedIn, referrals, career fairs; skimming by university and keywords
2	How confident are you that a junior CV shows what they can do?	"Not very": grades and projects don't show real skill or teamwork
3	Tell me about a hire who looked great on paper but couldn't do the job.	A real, costly mistake confirms the pain
4	Do you lean towards certain universities? Why?	A shortcut used when skill can't be verified: the core thesis
5	Do you run a take-home test? How long, and how many engineer hours does review take?	Review time and drop-off: the cost SkillBridge replaces
6	Has a certificate ever changed a shortlisting decision? Which one?	What makes a credential count: independent checking, a real pass mark

#	Ask	Listen for
7	(Show a CV alone and the same CV with a certified result.) Which do you take forward, and why?	Which parts they trust: the work, rubric owner, engineer note, contribution record
8	What would make you suspect it was gamed or done by AI?	Anti-cheating needs: a short live explanation, comparison across candidates
9	Would you accept it instead of your take-home? What would it take?	Conditions: their own brief, their engineer's sign-off
10	Would your company pay for this? From which budget, instead of what?	A named budget and an alternative it replaces; silence means the pain isn't sharp enough

For an engineer who could own a brief, ask instead: a small backlog task with no production or customer data; the four or five things they'd judge it on; review time for the top three; whether they'd trust an AI ranking and what they'd spot-check; and who owns the students' code.

Appendix C: Company objections by tier (hypotheses, not evidence)

The product stays the same; the pain it solves shifts with company size. These are hypotheses to test in interviews, not findings.

Tier	Likely objection	How SkillBridge answers
Startup (10–50 people)	"I hire for ability, not pedigree. Can you show me that?"	Scores on their own brief plus each student's contribution record: the skill signal they want
Startup	"I need someone soon, with no setup."	The engineer sends one brief and criteria; SkillBridge runs it and returns a ranked shortlist. "Three zips and a deadline"

Tier	Likely objection	How SkillBridge answers
Startup	“No budget. Why not just post on LinkedIn?”	Their post gets buried; on SkillBridge the challenge is what attracts students. Low or no cost to post during the pilot
Mid-size (a few hundred, HR team)	“How does this fit my hiring process?”	It replaces the take-home stage; a short live explanation stays. Results should export to their applicant-tracking system (to build)
Mid-size	“Is the score fair and defensible?”	Their own rubric, engineer sign-off, the same task for every candidate, a spot-checked AI ranking
Enterprise (strong brand)	“I already get thousands of applicants and run hackathons.”	Their problem is filtering, not supply: scored, attributed work on their own brief, kept over time instead of a one-off event
Enterprise	“What about GDPR and legal exposure?”	Explicit student opt-in to share; students keep their code; assessment use only. Needs a full legal answer before any enterprise pilot

Startups are the likely first customers: they care least about university names and decide fastest.